SOUTHERN REGION HERITAGE TRAIL



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Kanye Kgotla in 2011

DEBSWANA JWANENG MINE

Introduction

Through the Southern Region Heritage Trail, the Botswana National Museum offers a fresh look at the diversification of the tourism sector. Cultural & natural heritage sites are linked with traditional tourist destinations in the Southern parts of Botswana to offer an overwhelmingly complete package for the tourist.

The promotion of these heritage sites for tourism purposes is based on the growing need to diversify the country's tourism industry. The development of traditional practices at some natural and cultural heritage sites can increase conservation and management of these heritage resources. This will also contribute towards poverty eradication among rural communities where most of these sites are located.

The Southern Region Heritage Trail provides a limitless choice of fascinating places to visit. A visit to these destinations takes you through Botswana's oldest geological formations, unimpeded folklores, legends of mystic beings and sacred sites whose spirituality is unique to this region only.

NATURAL & CULTURAL Sites

1 Livingstone's Memorial

The Livingstone Memorial is an important part of the trail of the legendary missionary, traveller, explorer and medical doctor, David Livingstone in Botswana.

Livingstone's missionary work among the Bakwena people began with the establishment of Kolobeng Mission Station in 1847. His famous journey into the wilderness and interiors of Southern Africa started off from Kolobeng station.



Livingstone's house in 1901. Picture from Campbell & Main, 2003.

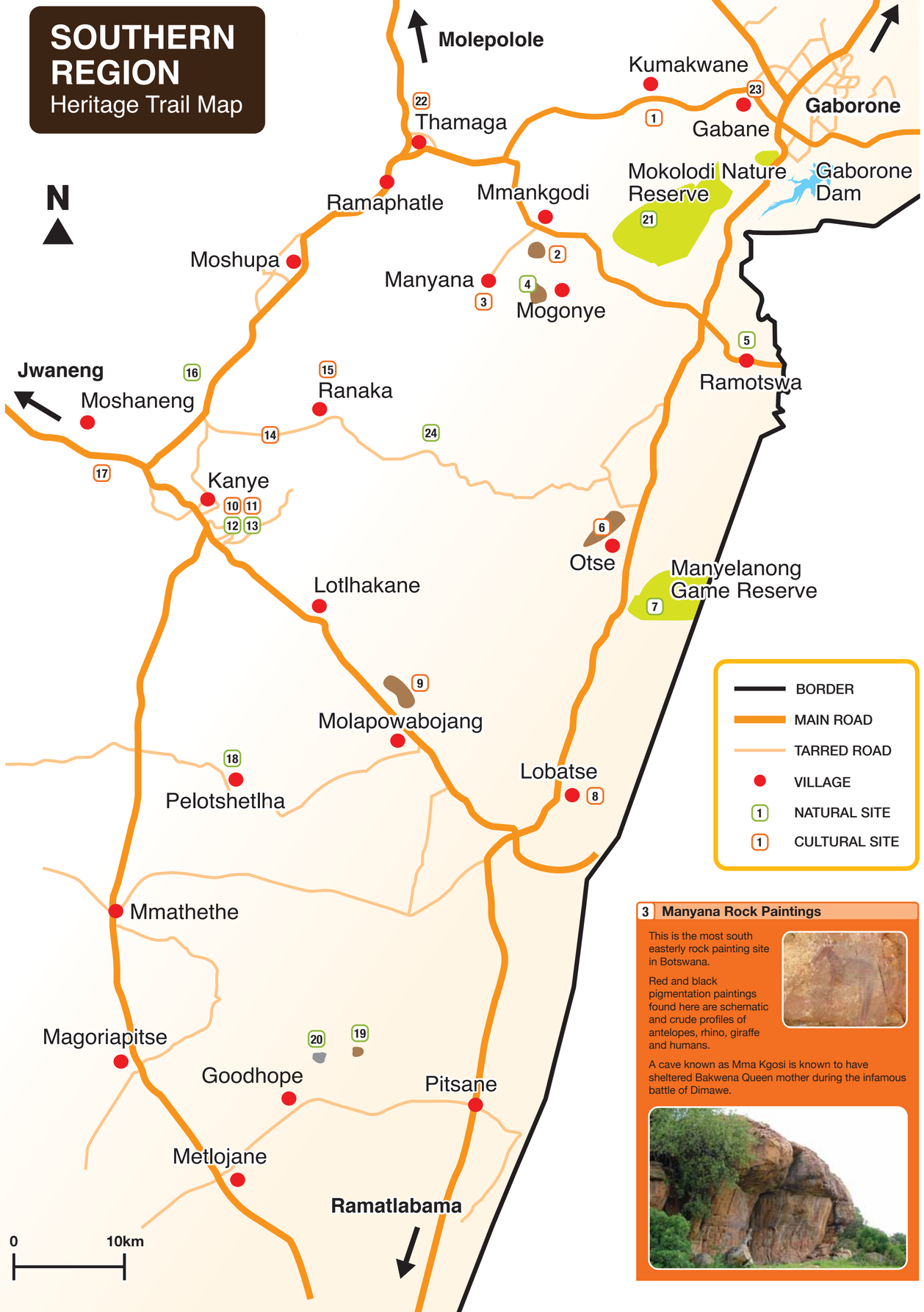
2 Dimawe

This is the battlefield where Batswana people fought off Transvaal Boer invasion under the leadership of Kgosi Sechele I of Bakwena in 1852. The Boers, angered by Sechele's increased interest in buying guns and cannons, attacked the Bakwena in order to disarm them.

This war is the most significant historic event that helped shape modern day Botswana.







3 Manyana Rock Paintings

This is the most south easterly rock painting site in Botswana.

Red and black pigmentation paintings found here are schematic and crude profiles of antelopes, rhino, giraffe and humans.

A cave known as Mma Kgosi is known to have sheltered Bakwena Queen mother during the infamous battle of Dimawe.

4 Mogonye Gorges

Several gorges found in the hills around Mogonye village form part of the Gaborone Dam catchment area. Mmamotshwane gorge is the most outstanding of these gorges.

Some gentle waterfalls and pools found in Mmamotshwane gorge support many plant and animal species. Several myths and stories of creatures of the spiritual world associated with the gorge will make your visit interesting.



5 Ramotswa Dolomites

Dikgatlampi, as they are known in Ramotswa, are one of the oldest geological formations found in Botswana.

Stromatolites found in these early rock formations demonstrate blue/green algae as early evidence of life on earth about 2,500 million years ago.



6 Lentswe la Baratani

The legend of Lentswe la Baratani is a famous romantic epic of two young lovers set in the traditional village of Otse.

The fable climaxes with the disappearance of the two lovers into Lentswe la Baratani Hill in protest of the denouncement of their will to marry each other.

The fate of the lovers is deeply shrouded in mystery. Some believe the two lovers climbed the hill and committed suicide. Others suggest that they hid in a sacred area. The climbing of Lentswe la Baratani has been forbidden since that day.



7 Manyelanong Game Reserve

This game reserve is the breeding ground of the endangered Cape Griffon vultures.



The reserve was established in 1986 to protect vultures which nestle in the cliffs of the hills. The name *Manyelanong* means where the vultures defecate.

On the lower slopes of *Manyelanong*, remains of a historic stone walled Sotho-Tswana village are visible.

NATURAL & CULTURAL Sites

8 Samora Machel Memorial



This house is an upcoming “museum”. It is located in Peleng township at Lobatse.

Mozambican liberation struggle leader Samora Machel and his entourage lived here on several occasions in the 1970s.

9 Mosenekatse

The lower slopes of an imposing two peaked hill to the north of Molapowabojang has remains of a lost Sotho-Tswana village. Some stone enclosures and house foundations with courtyards are found on the western end of Mosenekatse Hill.

The central hillock and the high western shoulder of Mosenekatse’s peak boast the highest concentration of stone walls. Scatters of pottery and stone walls found on the northwestern slope are considered sacred.



13 Mmakgodumo Dam



This is one of the largest dam ever to be built in Botswana through a self reliance programme. The dam was the brain child of Kgosi Bathoen II.

A vegetable garden, nursery, eucalyptus plantation and a nearby bird sanctuary were subsequently developed around the dam.

Mmakgodumo Dam is considered to be the home of a large mythic snake whose wife stays in the Kgwakgwe Hills. A long stone wall built to resemble this mythic snake is a popular destination for local tourists.



14 Ranaka Stone Walls



The upper and lower slopes of the hill to the west of Matialo is adorned with remains of refuge Sotho-Tswana stone walls, Late Stone Age artifacts and relics of early farming villages.

The top of the hill offers a compelling and panoramic view of rain fed farms, opportunistic dams and residential encroachment of the Bangwaketse’s capital of Kanye.



Panoramic view looking north towards Moshupa at Polokwe.

Picture Courtesy of Botswana Tourism Organisation, 2011

10 Bathoen II Museum



This museum houses ethnographic collections and art exhibits of the Bangwaketse and surrounding villages.

The museum was started as an effort to preserve collections of Kgosi Bathoen II in the 1990s.

11 Bathoen II Statue



The magnificent statue of Kgosi Bathoen II of Bangwaketse was unveiled in August 2011 to honour his visionary leadership.

Bathoen II’s statue stands aloof in the centre of Kanye the capital of the Bangwaketse to signify his stature as a visionary leader.

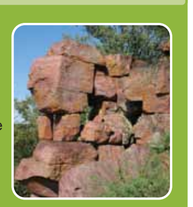
12 Pharing Gorge



This gorge begins not so far from Ntsweng, the royal kgotla and residence of the Bangwaketse royalty. The gorge has a perennial spring which is considered to have healing powers.

Pharing gorge is considered sacred and taboos associated with it are strictly followed. This is done to avert punishment from ancestral spirits which are known to inhabit the massive cliffs and caverns of the gorge.

15 Mmalogage Gorge



Mmalogage is the southern most of several gorges found around the village of Lekgolobotlo.

This gorge boasts the rare chance of being one of the few known perennial gorges that flow in a southerly direction in Botswana.



16 Polokwe View Point

“.. I could see perhaps to the distance of 30 miles to the north. The country consists of mountains and valleys, covered with forests of Acacias, wild olives, mimosas and other trees. In the kloofs, plenty of water is found, and the vegetation assumes a fresher and greener appearance…”

Alfred Dolman, 1924. In the Footsteps of Livingstone



17 Lowe



Lowe reiterates the legend of Matsieng; the one legged giant who emerged out of a water-hole followed by his people, domestic animals and wildlife.

Lowe is believed to be the creator of the Batswana people who sent Matsieng and the entire Batswana people out of the belly of the earth to inhabit the earth.

Lowe site which consists of the right foot and sacred water holes is found in the southern most part of the country.



18 Pelotshetlha Lithops



Also known as stone plants, Pelotshetlha lithops are a rare plant species that is endemic to Diabo Hill in Botswana.

Pelotshetlha lithops produce attractive flowers between May and June.

Their sensual shapes have earned them interesting names such as *marago a banyana* among the local people. The plants have no known medicinal use.

19 Kgoro Hill



The last known Sotho-Tswana stone walls in sourthern Botswana occur on a dome shaped hill at Kgoro.

At this site houses were built on raised platforms surrounded by low stone enclosures on the northern slopes of the hill. The upper slopes of the hill and its platform were reserved for large defensive stone enclosures during the tormenting Mfecane period.

There is also a solitary engraving of a footprint to the west of Kgoro Hill which is considered to be that of Matsieng.

20 Kgoro Pan

Kgoro Pan is a massive depression to the south of Kgoro Hill. It is one of the most panoramic pans in the southern region. Partial inundation of jointed rocks of the Kgoro Complex form scenic features of the pan during the rainy season.

The pan is host to migratory stork species, flamingoes, ducks and opportunistic birds such as the secretary bird. Cattle, donkeys, goats and sheep that gather around the pan for an occasional drink, add a spectacle to the scenery of the pan.



21 Mokolodi Nature Reserve

Nature lovers and those tired of the city bustle, can be treated to game drives, horse back safari, guided tours, rhino tracking, giraffe tracking, enchanting walks with trained elephants, cheetah visits and night tracking of leopards at this nature reserve.

A wide range of animals such as kudu, warthogs, impala, springboks, eland, baboons, vervet monkeys, white rhinos, zebras can be spotted in the reserve.



22 Botswelelo Centre (Thamaga)



This ceramic centre is famous for its unusual scratched decoration motifs. Colourful traditional pots made depict decoration styles of Botswana’s traditional huts.



23 Gabane Pottery

Gabane Pottery was established in the 1990s and utilizes the wheel technique to produce a wide range of vases, bowls and elegant tea sets.

African Terra cotta pots and exquisitely handcrafted sculptures are produced in this centre.



24 Saxon Studio (Ranaka)

This pottery centre combines artistic imagination with sheer humour to produce pottery that is visually appealing.

The Saxon Studio was established in 2001 to cater for the production of gifts and souvenirs due to the increase in demand by tourists who visit the Southern part of Botswana.

